

Poetic Devices & Language Analysis ★

GL-style Poem Comprehension — copy every box below into your notes

🔪 FULL DEVICES GLOSSARY — COPY THIS ALL DOWN

DEVICE	DEFINITION	EXAMPLE	TYPICAL EFFECT
Simile	Compares two things using "like" or "as".	"The wind howled like a wolf."	Makes an image vivid by linking it to something familiar/dangerous.
Metaphor	Says one thing IS another (no "like"/"as").	"The moon was a lantern."	Stronger and more direct than simile — suggests the two things are truly alike.
Extended metaphor	A metaphor continued across several lines or the whole poem.	Describing grief as a "storm" for a whole stanza.	Builds a deeper, layered comparison; shows the idea is central to the poem.
Personification	Giving human qualities to non-human things.	"The trees whispered secrets."	Makes nature/objects feel alive, can create warmth or menace.
Alliteration	Repeated consonant sound at the start of nearby words.	"Silent, silver, sliding stream."	Creates rhythm, can mimic a sound (soft/harsh) or link ideas together.
Assonance	Repeated vowel sound within nearby words.	"The light of the fire flies high."	Creates musicality, can slow down or speed up the line's sound.
Sibilance	Repeated "s" sounds.	"The snake slid silently."	Often creates a hissing, sneaky, or soothing effect.
Onomatopoeia	A word that imitates the sound it describes.	"crash", "buzz", "whisper".	Makes the reader hear the scene, adds realism.
Imagery	Descriptive language that appeals to any of the five senses.	"The bread's warm, buttery smell filled the kitchen."	Helps the reader picture, hear, smell, taste or feel the scene.
Symbolism	An object/image that represents a bigger idea.	A wilting flower symbolising lost youth.	Adds deeper meaning beyond the literal description.
Hyperbole	Deliberate exaggeration.	"I've told you a million times."	Emphasises strong emotion, can add humour or urgency.
Oxymoron	Two contradictory words placed together.	"bittersweet", "deafening silence".	Shows conflicting or complicated emotion.
Repetition	A word or phrase repeated for effect.	"Never, never, never again."	Emphasises importance, can build tension or show obsession.
Rhetorical question	A question asked for effect, not to get an answer.	"Why must the summer end?"	Draws the reader in, shows the speaker's inner emotion/doubt.
Emotive language	Words deliberately chosen to trigger a	"abandoned", "trembling",	Directly manipulates the reader's emotional response.

	strong feeling.	"shattered".	
Contrast / juxtaposition	Placing two very different ideas or images side by side.	A bright festival next to an empty, dark house.	Highlights the difference, can create irony or sadness.

Exam tip: never just NAME a device. Naming it is worth almost nothing on its own — the marks are in the EXPLANATION of its effect (see Worksheet 1's P.E.E.L. structure).

✎ STRUCTURE 1 — THE S.M.I.L.E. SPOTTING METHOD

STRUCTURE 1 OF 5

S.M.I.L.E. — use this on your first annotation pass

1. **S — Similes/metaphors** — underline every comparison in the poem.
2. **M — Mood words** — circle any word that instantly creates a feeling (dark, gentle, cold, joyful).
3. **I — Imagery** — box any phrase that appeals to a sense (sight, sound, smell, touch, taste).
4. **L — Line patterns** — mark short lines, repeated lines, or lines that break the rhythm.
5. **E — Emotive/strong language** — star any deliberately powerful word choice.

✎ STRUCTURE 2 — THE 5-STEP "EFFECT OF A WORD/PHRASE" METHOD

STRUCTURE 2 OF 5

When a question asks "what effect does the word/phrase ____ have?"

1. Give the LITERAL meaning of the word first, in your own words.
2. Give the CONNOTATION (the extra feeling attached to it) — e.g. "shattered" doesn't just mean broken, it suggests something sudden, violent and impossible to fix.
3. Say what SENSE it appeals to, if any (sight/sound/touch/smell/taste).
4. Say what MOOD it adds to the poem as a whole.
5. LINK it back to the poem's theme (Worksheet 1, R.E.A.D. step D).

STRUCTURE 3 OF 5

Use these phrases to sound like a top-band answer

- "This word choice suggests..."
- "This creates an atmosphere/impression of..."
- "This implies that the speaker feels..."
- "The effect of this is to make the reader picture/hear/imagine..."
- "This device is effective because it..."
- "This connects to the poem's wider theme of... because..."
- "The contrast between ____ and ____ emphasises..."
- "By repeating ____, the poet reinforces the idea that..."

✎ STRUCTURE 4 — THE TONE & MOOD LADDER

STRUCTURE 4 OF 5

Step-by-step for any tone/mood/feeling question

1. Find 2–3 words in the poem that carry strong feeling.
2. Decide: is the overall feeling positive, negative, or mixed/ambiguous?
3. Pick ONE precise tone word rather than a vague one — e.g. "nostalgic" or "wistful" instead of just "sad"; "triumphant" instead of just "happy".
4. Check: does the tone change partway through the poem? (Many GL poems shift tone in the final stanza.) If yes, describe both tones and where the shift happens.
5. Support your tone word with a direct quote.

✎ STRUCTURE 5 — SPEAKER & PERSPECTIVE CHECKLIST

STRUCTURE 5 OF 5

Tick off these 5 checks for any "who is speaking / whose viewpoint" question

1. Is the poem written in first person ("I"), second person ("you"), or third person ("he/she/they")?
2. Is the speaker an adult looking back, a child in the moment, or an outside narrator?
3. Does the speaker seem to know everything, or are they confused/uncertain about something?
4. Does the speaker's attitude change between the start and the end of the poem?
5. Would a different person (e.g. someone else in the poem) describe the same event differently? If the question asks this, explain the difference using evidence.

✎ PRECISE TONE WORDS — BUILD YOUR VOCABULARY

INSTEAD OF "HAPPY", TRY:	joyful, elated, content, triumphant, hopeful, playful, serene
INSTEAD OF "SAD", TRY:	mournful, wistful, nostalgic, melancholic, regretful, forlorn, despairing
INSTEAD OF "SCARED", TRY:	anxious, uneasy, apprehensive, terrified, wary, unsettled
INSTEAD OF "ANGRY", TRY:	bitter, resentful, indignant, frustrated, defiant
INSTEAD OF "CALM", TRY:	peaceful, tranquil, serene, reflective, still

Copy this rule: "A precise tone word plus one piece of evidence always beats a vague tone word with no evidence." Practise swapping "sad" or "happy" for a stronger word every time you write.

QUICK PRACTICE — FILL THIS IN NOW

Pick any word from a poem you've studied recently and apply Structure 2:

Word/phrase chosen: _____

Literal meaning:

.....

Connotation (extra feeling):

.....

Sense it appeals to: _____ Mood it adds: _____

Link to theme:

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